EXAMPLE 3.9

Calculation of Percent Composition

Analysis of a 12.04-g sample of a liquid compound composed of carbon, hydrogen, and nitrogen showed it to contain 7.34 g C, 1.85 g H, and 2.85 g N. What is the percent composition of this compound?

Solution

To calculate percent composition, divide the experimentally derived mass of each element by the overall mass of the compound, and then convert to a percentage:

$$\%\,\mathrm{C} = \frac{7.34\ \mathrm{g\ C}}{12.04\ \mathrm{g\ compound}} \times 100\% = 61.0\%$$
$$\%\,\mathrm{H} = \frac{1.85\ \mathrm{g\ H}}{12.04\ \mathrm{g\ compound}} \times 100\% = 15.4\%$$
$$\%\,\mathrm{N} = \frac{2.85\ \mathrm{g\ N}}{12.04\ \mathrm{g\ compound}} \times 100\% = 23.7\%$$

The analysis results indicate that the compound is 61.0% C, 15.4% H, and 23.7% N by mass.

Check Your Learning

A 24.81-g sample of a gaseous compound containing only carbon, oxygen, and chlorine is determined to contain 3.01 g C, 4.00 g O, and 17.81 g Cl. What is this compound's percent composition?

Answer:

12.1% C, 16.1% O, 71.79% Cl

Determining Percent Composition from Molecular or Empirical Formulas

Percent composition is also useful for evaluating the relative abundance of a given element in different compounds of known formulas. As one example, consider the common nitrogen-containing fertilizers ammonia (NH_3), ammonium nitrate (NH_4NO_3), and urea (CH_4N_2O). The element nitrogen is the active ingredient for agricultural purposes, so the mass percentage of nitrogen in the compound is a practical and economic concern for consumers choosing among these fertilizers. For these sorts of applications, the percent composition of a compound is easily derived from its formula mass and the atomic masses of its constituent elements. A molecule of NH_3 contains one N atom weighing 14.01 amu and three H atoms weighing a total of (3 × 1.008 amu) = 3.024 amu. The formula mass of ammonia is therefore (14.01 amu + 3.024 amu) = 17.03 amu, and its percent composition is:

$$\%\,\mathrm{N} = \frac{14.01\ \mathrm{amu\ N}}{17.03\ \mathrm{amu\ NH_3}} \times 100\% = 82.27\%$$
$$\%\,\mathrm{H} = \frac{3.024\ \mathrm{amu\ H}}{17.03\ \mathrm{amu\ NH_3}} \times 100\% = 17.76\%$$

This same approach may be taken considering a pair of molecules, a dozen molecules, or a mole of molecules, etc. The latter amount is most convenient and would simply involve the use of molar masses instead of atomic and formula masses, as demonstrated Example 3.10. As long as the molecular or empirical formula of the compound in question is known, the percent composition may be derived from the atomic or molar masses of the compound's elements.

EXAMPLE 3.10

Determining Percent Composition from a Molecular Formula

Aspirin is a compound with the molecular formula $C_9H_8O_4$. What is its percent composition?

Solution

To calculate the percent composition, the masses of C, H, and O in a known mass of $C_9H_8O_4$ are needed. It is convenient to consider 1 mol of $C_9H_8O_4$ and use its molar mass (180.159 g/mole, determined from the chemical formula) to calculate the percentages of each of its elements:

$$\%\,\mathrm{C} = \frac{9\ \text{mol C} \times \text{molar mass C}}{\text{molar mass } C_9H_8O_4} \times 100 = \frac{9 \times 12.01\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100 = \frac{108.09\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100$$

$$\%\,\mathrm{C} = 60.00\%\,\mathrm{C}$$

$$\%\,\mathrm{H} = \frac{8\ \text{mol H} \times \text{molar mass H}}{\text{molar mass } C_9H_8O_4} \times 100 = \frac{8 \times 1.008\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100 = \frac{8.064\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100$$

$$\%\,\mathrm{H} = 4.476\%\,\mathrm{H}$$

$$\%\,\mathrm{O} = \frac{4\ \text{mol O} \times \text{molar mass O}}{\text{molar mass } C_9H_8O_4} \times 100 = \frac{4 \times 16.00\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100 = \frac{64.00\ \text{g/mol}}{180.159\ \text{g/mol}} \times 100$$

$$\%\,\mathrm{O} = 35.52\%$$

Note that these percentages sum to equal 100.00% when appropriately rounded.

Check Your Learning

To three significant digits, what is the mass percentage of iron in the compound Fe_2O_3?

Answer:

69.9% Fe

Determination of Empirical Formulas

As previously mentioned, the most common approach to determining a compound's chemical formula is to first measure the masses of its constituent elements. However, keep in mind that chemical formulas represent the relative *numbers*, not masses, of atoms in the substance. Therefore, any experimentally derived data involving mass must be used to derive the corresponding numbers of atoms in the compound. This is accomplished using molar masses to convert the mass of each element to a number of moles. These molar amounts are used to compute whole-number ratios that can be used to derive the empirical formula of the substance. Consider a sample of compound determined to contain 1.71 g C and 0.287 g H. The corresponding numbers of atoms (in moles) are:

$$1.71\ \text{g C} \times \frac{1\ \text{mol C}}{12.01\ \text{g C}} = 0.142\ \text{mol C}$$

$$0.287\ \text{g H} \times \frac{1\ \text{mol H}}{1.008\ \text{g H}} = 0.284\ \text{mol H}$$

Thus, this compound may be represented by the formula $C_{0.142}H_{0.284}$. Per convention, formulas contain whole-number subscripts, which can be achieved by dividing each subscript by the smaller subscript:

$$\mathrm{C}_{\frac{0.142}{0.142}}\ \mathrm{H}_{\frac{0.284}{0.142}}\ \text{or}\ \mathrm{CH_2}$$

(Recall that subscripts of "1" are not written but rather assumed if no other number is present.)

The empirical formula for this compound is thus CH_2. This may or may not be the compound's *molecular formula* as well; however, additional information is needed to make that determination (as discussed later in this section).

Consider as another example a sample of compound determined to contain 5.31 g Cl and 8.40 g O. Following the same approach yields a tentative empirical formula of:

$$\mathrm{Cl}_{0.150}\mathrm{O}_{0.525} = \mathrm{Cl}_{\frac{0.150}{0.150}}\ \mathrm{O}_{\frac{0.525}{0.150}} = \mathrm{ClO}_{3.5}$$

In this case, dividing by the smallest subscript still leaves us with a decimal subscript in the empirical formula. To convert this into a whole number, multiply each of the subscripts by two, retaining the same atom ratio and yielding Cl_2O_7 as the final empirical formula.

In summary, empirical formulas are derived from experimentally measured element masses by:

1. Deriving the number of moles of each element from its mass
2. Dividing each element's molar amount by the smallest molar amount to yield subscripts for a tentative empirical formula
3. Multiplying all coefficients by an integer, if necessary, to ensure that the smallest whole-number ratio of subscripts is obtained

Figure 3.11 outlines this procedure in flow chart fashion for a substance containing elements A and X.

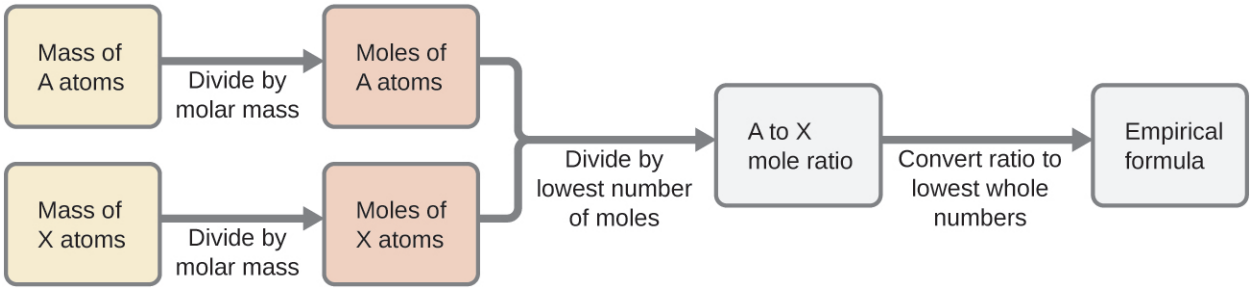


FIGURE 3.11 The empirical formula of a compound can be derived from the masses of all elements in the sample.

EXAMPLE 3.11

Determining a Compound's Empirical Formula from the Masses of Its Elements

A sample of the black mineral hematite (Figure 3.12), an oxide of iron found in many iron ores, contains 34.97 g of iron and 15.03 g of oxygen. What is the empirical formula of hematite?



FIGURE 3.12 Hematite is an iron oxide that is used in jewelry. (credit: Mauro Cateb)

Solution

This problem provides the mass in grams of each element. Begin by finding the moles of each:

$$34.97\ \text{g Fe}\left(\frac{\text{mol Fe}}{55.85\ \text{g}}\right) = 0.6261\ \text{mol Fe}$$

$$15.03\ \text{g O}\left(\frac{\text{mol O}}{16.00\ \text{g}}\right) = 0.9394\ \text{mol O}$$

Next, derive the iron-to-oxygen molar ratio by dividing by the lesser number of moles:

$$\frac{0.6261}{0.6261} = 1.000 \text{ mol Fe}$$
$$\frac{0.9394}{0.6261} = 1.500 \text{ mol O}$$

The ratio is 1.000 mol of iron to 1.500 mol of oxygen ($Fe_1O_{1.5}$). Finally, multiply the ratio by two to get the smallest possible whole number subscripts while still maintaining the correct iron-to-oxygen ratio:

$$2\,(Fe_1O_{1.5}) = Fe_2O_3$$

The empirical formula is Fe_2O_3.

Check Your Learning

What is the empirical formula of a compound if a sample contains 0.130 g of nitrogen and 0.370 g of oxygen?

Answer:

N_2O_5

LINK TO LEARNING

For additional worked examples illustrating the derivation of empirical formulas, watch the brief video (http://openstax.org/l/16empforms) clip.

Deriving Empirical Formulas from Percent Composition

Finally, with regard to deriving empirical formulas, consider instances in which a compound's percent composition is available rather than the absolute masses of the compound's constituent elements. In such cases, the percent composition can be used to calculate the masses of elements present in any convenient mass of compound; these masses can then be used to derive the empirical formula in the usual fashion.

EXAMPLE 3.12

Determining an Empirical Formula from Percent Composition

The bacterial fermentation of grain to produce ethanol forms a gas with a percent composition of 27.29% C and 72.71% O (Figure 3.13). What is the empirical formula for this gas?